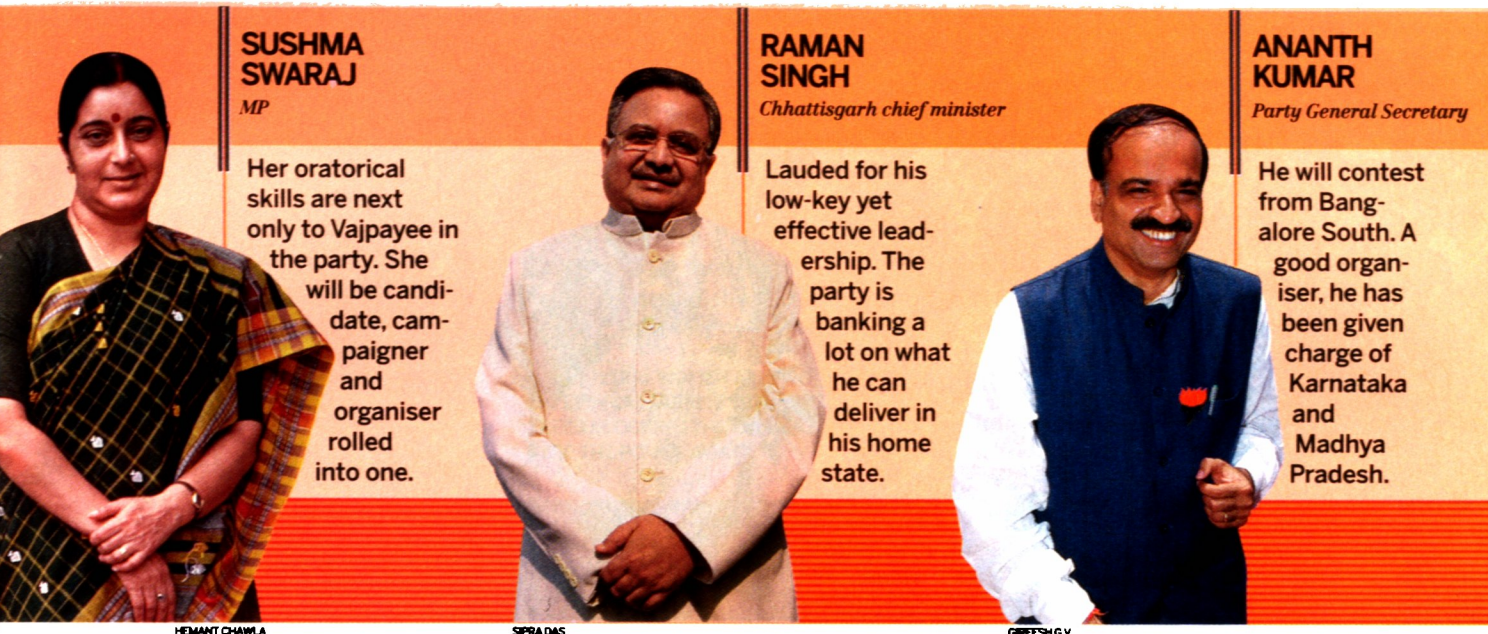




SUSHMA SWARAJ

MP

Her oratorical skills are next only to Vajpayee in the party. She will be candidate, campaigner and organiser rolled into one.

HEMANT CHAWLA

RAMAN SINGH

Chhattisgarh chief minister

Lauded for his low-key yet effective leadership. The party is banking a lot on what he can deliver in his home state.

SIPRA DAS

ANANTH KUMAR

Party General Secretary

He will contest from Bangalore South. A good organiser, he has been given charge of Karnataka and Madhya Pradesh.

GREESH GV

At the end of the National Executive and Council, if anything positive emerged, it was the realisation that the party was not prepared to regain power, that they were facing a change-or-be-damned situation. Based on the inputs from state leaders and its in-house analysts, it was decided that the BJP has to be *nirgut* (without factions), *ekjut* (united) and *ekmukh* (talk in one voice) if it wants to form the next government. The party analysts unequivocally told the leadership that the way things were going, there was no way that the BJP would improve on its present tally of 138 in the Lok Sabha.

The party had its central campaign committee in place which was in charge of the planning and implementation of strategies at the national level. Chaired by the party president and headed by senior leader Venkaiah Naidu, it has now been decided to decentralise the functioning of the committee. The state leaders have been given the responsibility for their respective states. Shanta Kumar will take charge of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Haryana, along with Bhagat Singh Koshiyari.

Party General Secretary Arun Jaitley—after wriggling out of contesting elections—wanted to be the national election manager, like the late Pramod Mahajan. However, amid stiff opposition from some other leaders, especially the GenNext ones, he was given the charge of states like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Haryana, Punjab and Delhi—places where the party does not have much space to manoeuvre.

Advani tried his best to be even-handed in the distribution of work. Even his praise was not just reserved for Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi. Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh chief ministers Raman Singh and Shivraj Singh Chouhan respectively, also received their quota of good words from the prime ministerial candidate. His usual lieutenants, including Sushma Swaraj and Naidu, were also appropriately praised. There is obviously an effort to expand and democratise the second-rung. There won't be a first among the equals at the second level, Modi may take notice. He has been given charge of organising elections in Maharashtra, Goa, Daman and

Diu in addition to Gujarat. Swaraj, herself contesting from Bhopal, will look after the crucial states of Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand. Naidu, who too was not "in the mood" to contest, has been given charge of the south, which effectively means only Karnataka.

This sudden love affair with the second-rung leadership tells another story. Advani may be the prime ministerial candidate but he is not yet Vajpayee. So the entire campaign will not be built on "Advani for PM". No personality cult because there is no personality worthy of it after Vajpayee's retirement. "After interacting with leaders and *karyakartas* of different states, we realised that there was an urgent need to energise the cadre. They were all in a pessimistic frame of mind and had accepted defeat even before the fight. Drastic measures were needed. We think that the conclave was a success since it led to the admission that things were bleak. And admission is the first step to correction. So now we are on the corrective path, and will surely emerge winners," said a party leader. Such optimism, unfortunately, is not matched by ideas or ideology. ■